

SUBSTANCE OVER STYLE

■ By Saurabh Shukla

British Prime Minister Gordon Brown sat down in New Delhi for a summit with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh on January 21 amid a "Scottish chill" in the weather. But the warmth of the relationship inside Hyderabad House more than made up for the frosty winds outside.

At the talks, a meeting of minds between the two was apparent—Brown, 57, a Scotsman, who had shaped British economic policy as its chancellor of exchequer from 1997 to 2006 and Manmohan, 76, the

support the membership of India in the UNSC and also reform of the Security Council for the future. We agree that international institutions should be reformed to deal with the challenges of the 21st century and ensure more representatives of the new global order."

Pitted against the boyish looks of his predecessor Tony Blair, Brown held his own, with generous one-liners and compliments as he met the ministers and others at the protocol line-up. During his two-day trip, Brown impressed his hosts with his spontaneity and frankness. "He was not flamboyant but came across as a

SIPRA DAS



Cambridge-educated economist who had shaped the contours of India's liberalisation programme as the country's finance minister in 1991.

While the delegation-level talks had to be pruned, the two leaders extended their one-on-one parleys and stretched it over one-and-a-half hours, exchanging notes on taking the bilateral relationship forward and outlining a road map for future cooperation.

Brown also assured Manmohan that he would work proactively for India's entry to the UN Security Council (UNSC) and an enlarged G-8, the club of developed countries of the world. "We

CLOSE TIES: (top) PMs with their wives, young athletes meet Brown candid leader who is passionate about implementing the bilateral agenda," remarked a foreign office source.

For India, Brown's visit was the first by a major foreign dignitary in 2008 and was important as Britain has been one of India's closest strategic partners in Europe. While it may have shrunk from its status as the preeminent global power, it does have an influential place in the global high table as a permanent member of UNSC and G-8, besides the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG), and New Delhi realises that as its global

